

Chapter 9

Inauspicious events and their outcomes in Thulung

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The Thulung (Tibeto-Burman, Kiranti sub-group, Eastern Nepal) narrative corpus yields very few examples of precautioning clauses, even though such constructions are in fact fairly easy to obtain through elicitation. The precautioning construction is characterized by a) typologically unusual clause ordering, with the precautioning clause occurring before the preemptive clause; b) a negated optative form of the verb in the precautioning clause; c) subordination of the precautioning clause by means of a converbial form of the verb ‘to say’. Furthermore, precautioning clauses always show different subject from the pre-emptive clause, and a strong causal link across the two clauses, resulting in an avertive reading. A grammaticalization pathway is proposed for the development of this construction, originating from a lexical verb ‘be auspicious’. Other precautioning strategies are also found: an ‘otherwise’ (‘if not’) construction, calqued on Nepali, and a coordinated construction in which the first clause contains the precautioning event in the form of reported speech, using a finite form of the verb ‘to say’. In addition to precautioning strategies, Thulung also has an emphasis particle *sə* which takes on an apprehensional function (but only with 2nd person S, A or P), and can be interpreted as a prohibitive in certain situations. The apprehensive domain in Thulung is much richer than initially suggested by the corpus, making use of fixed morphosyntactic constructions and coopting other language mechanisms for the expression of different types of undesirability.



1 Introduction

Considering the notable absence¹ of South Asian languages from descriptions of the apprehensional domain, this contribution aims to illustrate how Thulung, spoken in Eastern Nepal, expresses the domain in question. As will be seen, there is indeed no dedicated morphology which “indicates that an event will potentially occur but is undesirable, with associated pragmatics of warning or threat” (Angelo & Schultze-Berndt 2016: 255). Thulung has nonetheless developed a means of expressing apprehension through a negative purpose construction, which this chapter will explore.

Thulung is an exclusively oral language of the Kiranti subgroup (Sino-Tibetan). Its verbal morphology is predominantly suffixal, with formatives used for derivation (associated motion, Aktionsart and valence changes), for the expression of arguments² and mood (optative or irrealis). Apprehension, as defined by Vuillermet (2018: 262), is a cover term that “encompasses many different nuances of an emotion triggered by an undesirable, possible event”. By this definition, the apprehensional domain in Thulung is expressed by means of a negative purpose construction, used to bring about the avoidance of a situation with a negative outcome. There is no morphology or construction for the expression of fear, which is instead conveyed through lexical means.³ Considering the poorly developed apprehensional domain in Thulung, one may wonder, as did one reviewer, whether it is for good reason that languages like Thulung are not present in typological research on apprehension, especially as, as will be seen below, there is evidence that the Thulung negative purpose construction is calqued from (Indo-Aryan) contact language Nepali (this is discussed in §2.1 below). It is my opinion that a

¹Vuillermet’s (2018) Table 3 “Terminology used crosslinguistically to refer to apprehensional functions” lists languages from South America, Australia, Papunesia, North America, Eurasia (Central Siberian Yupik) but none from South Asia.

²The personal indexes are portmanteaux indicating person/number/clusivity and role of up to two arguments, together with tense and, when relevant, imperative mood.

³This is either through a verb ‘to fear’, as in:

- (i) *Meram-ka phal-mu ŋis-ta.*
 DIST.DEM-ERG cut-INF fear-3SG.PST
 ‘He was afraid to cut [the finger].’ [Miyakma-Lakpa, 127]

or through the noun ‘fear’, as in:

- (ii) *A-ŋim-ka go ne a-kal khrep-to.*
 1SG.POSS-fear-1SG TOP 1SG.POSS-face cover-1SG>3SG.PST
 ‘I covered my face in fear.’ [Ghumne Pani, 97]

better, cross-linguistic understanding of the apprehension domain necessitates input from both languages where it is well-represented, as is the case of other languages described in this volume, and those where it is a considerably more minor phenomenon, as in Thulung, the latter providing useful insights about how a language without morphology can develop a strategy to express a category.

The structure of this contribution is as follows: in §2, I shall describe the Thulung negative purpose construction, proposing a development pathway based on the elements that make up the construction. I then present some related constructions, either an alternative means of expressing a similar function (the ‘if not’ construction, in §3) or relevant in that they represent alternative grammaticalizations from a same lexical source verb (§4), before concluding in §5.

2 The Thulung negative purpose construction

According to Lichtenberk (1995: 302), the precautioning function in language is made up of two subtypes: an *avertive* relationship, defined by a direct causal link between the two clauses, and an ‘*in-case*’ relationship, in which precautions are taken in case the apprehension-causing situation occurs but without seeking to avert it. The precautioning function is expressed through a negative purpose construction which – to my knowledge – does not have ‘in-case’ readings.

The terminology for the semantic content of the two clauses in the negative purpose construction is that adopted throughout this volume: the apprehension-causing situation is the outcome that must be averted, expressed through what I shall call the *precautioning clause*; the action taken to avoid the situation is expressed in the *pre-emptive clause*.

2.1 Presentation and main characteristics

The Thulung narrative corpus which I have assembled since 1999, and which constitutes just over ten hours of interlinearized material,⁴ yields the very low count of two examples of the negative purpose construction, seen in (1) and (2) (along with two examples of the equivalent positive purpose construction). The two other sources that exist for Thulung diverge considerably in terms of the presence of the construction. Allen (1975), the first grammatical description of Thulung, is accompanied by 17 pages of transcribed and glossed “straightforward narrative texts” (p. 140) (the fluent translation follows and is not part of the page

⁴Some of these annotated recordings can be found at: https://pangloss.cnrs.fr/corpus/Thulung_Rai

count) and ten pages of a transcribed and translated (but not glossed) “narrative text in ritual language” (p. 168). Allen’s corpus yields not a single instance of the negative purpose construction, nor of its positive counterpart. The second source of Thulung narrative material is a recent Thulung translation of the New Testament,⁵ which yields a great number of examples of negative and positive purpose constructions matching those discussed in this contribution and illustrated in examples (1) and (2). I have found negative purpose clauses to be easy to obtain through elicitation,⁶ and have made use of elicited material as well in the discussion presented here.

- (1) *Jakke biruwa bastu-ka me-po-mi-nu rwaksaka*
 small plant.species cattle-ERG NEG-eat-3PL>3SG-OPT SUB
ur-mu ba:si.
 surround-INF must
 ‘So that the cattle does not eat the small plants, we must surround them
 (with bamboo sticks).’ [verb dictionary]
- (2) *Lam rem-ben-mu ʌpthero me-dum-nu rwaksaka*
 path look-CAUS-INF difficult NEG-become.3SG-OPT SUB
pra-m-ri-m si-mu lam si-mu dʌmla homlowo gui
 create-1PL>3SG.PST-NMLZ die-INF path die-INF culture even.now 1DI
thu:lu-ka bet-to-ŋa be:-mim rwak-pa lwa bu.
 Thulung-ERG do-SIM.CVB-INT do-NMLZ say-NPST.PTCP story be.3SG
 ‘So that it is not difficult to show [others] the path [for dealing with a
 corpse], we created a path for dying, and even today we Thulung follow
 this “death culture”, and this is the story of that.’ [Miyakma-Lakpa, 136]

The construction in (1) features two clauses: the precautioning clause [*jakke biruwa bastu-ka me-po-mi-nu rwaksaka*], which expresses a possible negative outcome, and a pre-emptive clause [*urmu ba:si*], which expresses an action to take to avoid the negative outcome. The precautioning clause contains a negated verb in the optative mood followed by the subordinator *rwaksaka*, and is always a subordinate clause. The pre-emptive clause is always the main clause, which, in (1), contains an impersonal deontic necessity construction (see §4 below). Note that while the form of the verb in the precautioning clause must be a negative

⁵<https://thulungmedia.com/en/thulung-bible>

⁶By elicitation, I mean that I have gotten these constructions in response to describing a situation made up of two events, one with negative consequences and one which could help avoid the negative consequences.

optative, and it must be followed by subordinator *rwaksaka*, there are fewer constraints on the pre-emptive clause: an impersonal deontic necessity construction is common, but so too are finite verbs, as in (3).

- (3) *Tsəttə-mim-ka pi:masi me-bi-mi-nu rwaksaka*
 child-PL-ERG fruit NEG-beg-3PL>3SG-OPT SUB
thak-tu.
 hide-3SG>3SG.PST
 ‘So that the children wouldn’t beg for the fruit, he hid it.’ [elicited]

The negative optative is also found in independent clauses, as in (4),⁷ and expresses the speaker’s desire to avoid a situation. The optative, which occurs in a complete paradigm, i.e. with all three persons, is found with both positive and negative verbs. For examples of positive optative-marked verbs, see (15) and (16) below. (A proposed development path for the optative marker is described in §2.2.)

- (4) *Phe:ri phe:ri hopmam dzuθho-ra mi-grəms-i ma tika*
 again again like.this ritual.pollution-LOC NEG-meet-1PI CONJ bindi
ba:-mu mi-ba:si-nu rwak-i.
 wear-INF NEG-must-OPT say-1PI
 ‘We say “Let’s not meet again and again in this kind of ritual pollution, and may we not have to wear bindis again”.’ [Life in Mukli, 185]

The undesirability of the situation that is conveyed by the precautioning clause of the negative purpose construction, and which the pre-emptive action is meant to avoid, transparently comes from the negative optative form. The negative purpose construction is most often used to transmit expectations of what constitutes appropriate and inappropriate behavior, rather than to convey direct interdiction with respect to a specific action. This is probably why the pre-emptive clause often uses the impersonal deontic necessity construction, and not, as far as I can ascertain from elicitation, an imperative (this is also found to be the case in Upper Tanana Dene, see Lovick 2026 [this volume]). Thulung therefore does not conform to the cross-linguistic tendency, noted by Dixon (2009: 24), for the clause expressing the pre-emptive action (in his terminology, the focal clause)

⁷Thulung has, as discussed, an optative mood, used to express the desire that an event take place. Non-past verbs (unmarked for optative) in 1st person non-singular inclusive forms can have a hortative reading. This is contrasted, in (4), by translating ‘let’s’ for the hortative, and ‘may we’ for the optative.

of avertive-type constructions (subsumed within his possible consequence constructions) to contain positive or negative imperatives.

The formative *rwaksaka* is also used to subordinate both expressions of direct speech or thought⁸ to an utterance verb, as in (5), as well as other types of complement clauses, as in (6).

- (5) *Khamba-nim ref-to-m* *bu rwaksaka*
 Tibetan-F bring.up-1SG>3SG.PST-NMLZ be.3SG SUB
me-sə-θ-wa.
 NEG-tell-3SG>3SG-IRR
 ‘He had not told [anyone at home] that he had brought up [=married] a Tibetan woman.’ [Foundation, 122]
- (6) *Thulung-ka tha: lwas-tθ* *pɿila-ŋa oram rok-ta ma*
 Thulung-ERG realize-3SG>3SG.PST first-INT PROX.DEM come-3SG.PST CONJ
bu-mim rwaksaka tha: lwas-tθ.
 be-NMLZ SUB realize-3SG>3SG.PST
 ‘The Thulung realized, he realized that this one had arrived and stayed [there] first.’ (i.e. was therefore the rightful owner of the land) [Thulung Origin, 40–41]

At the same time, *rwaksaka* is also used, and synchronically analyzable, as an anterior converb for the verb *rwa:mu*, ‘say’, as in (7):

- (7) *ɿm-tsi ma ba-tsi rwak-saka mu hoʃ-dzəl-tsi ma ɿk-tsi*
 sleep-2DU CONJ stay-2DU say-ANT.CVB fire light-ANTIC-2DU CONJ go-2DU
ʔe.
 HS

‘Having said “sleep and stay here” they lit a fire and left.’ [Hansel, 24]

The converbal form in (7) is the presumed source for subordinator *rwaksaka* in (1), (2), (5) and (6), similarly to what is found in many Tibeto-Burman languages, where the grammaticalization of the verb ‘say’ to encode “causal, conditional, evidential, and purposive meanings” (Coupe 2018: 202) is often based on a converbal form (Coupe 2018: 200–201; Chappell 2008 for Sinitic languages; Matic & Pakendorf 2013 for Siberian languages).⁹ This pattern is also discussed from a ty-

⁸This conflation of saying and thinking is common in languages of Nepal; see Noonan (2006). Also, note that all reported speech in Thulung is expressed as direct speech.

⁹Matic & Pakendorf raise the possibility that Siberian *non-canonical* functions for the verb ‘say’ (among which is grammaticalization to a marker to subordinate purpose clauses) have “historical connections with similar structures in East and Southeast Asia, the Himalayas and South Asia and the Turkic and Turkic-influenced region spreading from Central Asia to the Balkans.” (Matic & Pakendorf 2013: 358).

pological perspective by Aikhenvald (2009: 387–390), who describes a pathway for the grammaticalization of verbs of reported speech into clause-chaining devices.¹⁰ The diachronic development of the subordinator probably accounts for the order of the clauses which is observed in the (negative) purpose construction and others involving material subordinated with *rwaksaka*.

Interestingly, Nepali has a strikingly similar structure to the Thulung negative purpose construction.^{11,12}

(8) Nepali

Dza:ɖo-le nA-mar-os bhAN-era luga lagai-di-ẽ.

cold-INSTR NEG-die-OPT say-CVB clothes wear-APPL-1SG.PST

‘So that he would not die of cold, I dressed him.’ [elicited]

The place of language contact in the use of this construction is worth considering: the constructions in Thulung and Nepali are close enough that it is reasonable to think of them as calques, raising the question of direction of borrowing. Thulung is in a situation of intensive contact with Nepali, with, to my knowledge, no remaining monolingual speakers. Evidence of borrowing from Nepali is found throughout the language, most prominently in the lexical and syntactic domains, but with consequences for the morphosyntax as well (see Lahaussais 2003 for a contact-induced shift in the position of the ergative split within the personal pronoun system). The contact situation itself suggests that the likely direction of borrowing is from Nepali into Thulung, but there are other clues as well. As mentioned above, the corpus that I have made use of herein is made up of three sub-corpora: my own data, collected from 1999 onwards; some transcribed and annotated textual data from N. J. Allen, collected in the late 1960’s and published in Allen (1975); and materials from recent translation efforts of the New Testament into Thulung, available online in their Devanagari transcription. The materials collected by Allen do not contain a single occurrence of the negative purpose construction; my data contains but very few; the New Testament translation contains a great many. This could of course be due to the size of the various corpora, the New Testament translation being by far the largest of the three. But the dates are possibly also of significance, with the earlier materials showing no

¹⁰ Aikhenvald provides examples from Dolakha Newar, Chantyal (both spoken in Nepal) and Galo.

¹¹ The equivalent of (8), which was provided by Rajesh Khatiwada, is found in Thulung in (18).

¹² The suffix *-os* has been called an injunctive in some grammatical descriptions of Nepali, and is used to “to express a wish or desire” (Matthews 1998: 197). The purposive construction is also described in the same section of the grammar (Matthews 1998: 199).

signs of the construction, and the more recent materials revealing its presence, suggestive of increased borrowing from Nepali, as evidenced elsewhere in the language as well.¹³

The fact that such a close mirror of the construction is found in Nepali as well raises some profound questions about the descriptions of categories that may in fact be marginal, as suggested by one reviewer. If the Thulung construction is calqued on the Nepali one, then does it deserve to be described here as part of the language's apparatus for the expression of apprehension? The fact is that all of the most important elements of the construction are widely used in Thulung: the negative optative, as well as subordination with *rwaksaka*. In that sense, even if the construction itself is calqued, the elements making it up are well attested in the language (even if they in turn are possibly the result of earlier borrowing, as may be the case for subordinator *rwaksaka*), and as such the construction reveals the language's ability to use what, at least synchronically, are "native" elements in order to express something for which a need has arisen (if we assume that the negative purpose construction is a recent phenomenon in Thulung).

As mentioned above, Thulung also has a positive purpose construction (again, with only two examples in my narrative corpus), which is symmetrical with the negative purpose construction described herein, consisting of an optative-marked clause, subordinate by *rwaksaka* to a main clause. It is exemplified in (9):

- (9) *Omsaka pho-nu rwaksaka bui-dʌ:la jak-tu.*
 like.this vomit.3SG-OPT SUB head-above hit-3SG>3SG.PST
 'So that he would vomit like this, he hit him on the head.' (in order to see what he had eaten) [Miyakma-Lakpa, 87]

The only other type of purpose clause in Thulung is one involving a motion verb,¹⁴ a construction that only occurs in an affirmative form. There is thus only a single way to express an action carried out for negative purpose, and that is the construction described above.

¹³A third possibility is of course that the New Testament suffers from translation bias, as it was presumably based on the Nepali version of the Bible. See Wälchli (2007) for more on bias and how this affects materials, particularly parallel corpora (such as the Bible), used in linguistic studies.

¹⁴These are of the type:

- (i) *Kefi phap-da ʌ:-mi.*
 girl pick.up-PURP go-3PL
 'They go to pick up the girl.'

2.2 Order of clauses and grammaticalization pathway

One notable characteristic of the construction is the order of clauses in the construction, which goes counter to typological tendencies: Dixon (2009: 39, 48) claims that for possible consequence clauses, many languages tend to move the focal clause (i.e., the pre-emptive clause) to the first position, giving prime importance to the expression of how to avert the negative consequence.¹⁵ In Thulung, the pre-emptive clause follows the precautioning clause, something which can be posited to come about from the development of the construction.

I propose the following stages for the development of the negative purpose construction:

1. an optative mood marker develops from the lexical verb *nɯmu* ‘be good, be auspicious’ (henceforth glossed ‘be.good’);
2. a negative optative marked clause is subordinated with *rwaksaka* and interpreted as a precautioning clause;
3. the resulting precautioning clause, coupled with a main clause, yields a negative purpose construction.

The forms that make up each stage along the pathway are still productively used.

2.2.1 Stage 1: Lexical verb *nɯmu* to optative mood marker

The lexical verb *nɯmu* ‘be good’ is illustrated in examples (10) and (11), where it appears in finite form and in participial form, respectively. The ability to occur with derivational suffixes,¹⁶ as in (10), and as a participle, as in (11), confirms its status as a lexical verb.

- (10) *Sɯ:-ka khok-u-lo wo me tsokho dɯ:*
 who-ERG cook-3SG>3SG-TEMP even DEM ritually.pure beer
nɯ-le ni.
 be.good-LIM.3SG indeed
 ‘Whoever cooks it, that ritually pure beer will end up good.’ [Bungarma, 135]

¹⁵Note, however, that Schmidtke-Bode (2009: 113ff) shows that, while VO languages have a strong preference for a purpose clause following the main clause, the data on OV languages (of which Thulung is one) is mixed as to the ordering of clauses.

¹⁶The derivational suffix in (10) is used to express what I call *liminal* Aktionsart, in other words a focus on the boundaries of the action. See Lahaussais (2020a,b).

- (11) *Ma:ke nu-pa khal-kam lwas-tu ʔe.*
 grain be.good-NPST.PTCP type-GEN see-3SG>3SG.PST HS
 ‘He saw a good type of grain.’ (when searching for a place to establish a settlement) [Miyakma-Chandra, 115]

I propose that the verb *nu* ‘be good’ develops into the optative marker through the reanalysis of two independent clauses into a mood-marked clause. In (12), the two independent clauses [*gu dalaŋa sa:*] and [*nu*] are in a paratactic relationship.

- (12) *Gu dala-ŋa sa: nu.*
 3SG fast-INT heal.3SG be.good.3SG
 ‘He will heal fast, that is good.’ [constructed]

The two clauses in a paratactic relationship are reinterpreted as a single clause (with the prosody of the construction as it currently stands suggesting this),¹⁷ and *nu* is reanalyzed as an optative mood marker, as in (13).

- (13) *Gu dala-ŋa sa:-nu.*
 3SG fast-INT heal.3SG-OPT
 ‘May he heal fast.’ [fieldnotes]

The fact that the 3SG non-past intransitive verb form has no overt indexation on the verb, which therefore occurs as a bare stem, results in there being no inflection marker in the space between the two finite verbs in (12). This could well have contributed to facilitating a reanalysis of *sa:* as a verb root and *nu* as a mood marker. Note that in present-day Thulung, the optative mood marker can be suffixed directly to the verb root or to an inflected verb stem, with both forms currently accepted by some speakers, as shown in (14).

- (14) *Ma:ke dzəmka si:-ru-nu/siŋ-nu rwaksaka go*
 grain carefully mature-3SG>3SG.PST-OPT/mature-OPT SUB 1SG
biruwa dzəmka khor-pu.
 small.weeds carefully hoe-1SG>3SG
 ‘So that the grain matures nicely, I hoe the small weeds with care.’
 [fieldnotes]

¹⁷ Another hint is that it is written as a single word in the translation of the New Testament by native Thulung speakers.

My Thulung corpus provides a number of examples of optative mood marker *-nɯ*, many of which are found in recordings of incantations and prayers. Some additional illustrations are given in (15) and (16).

- (15) *Go oram-nun tseŋ-si-ŋu he: dɯm-ŋu-lo dɯm-ŋu-nɯ*
 1SG DEM-SOC hang-REFL-1SG how become-1SG-TEMP **become-1SG-OPT**
rwak-ta ʔe.
 say-3SG.PST HS
 ‘And he said “I will hang myself with (i.e. onto) this, and however I become, may I become like that”.’ (man trying to escape from cave by grabbing onto monkey tail) [Redukpa, 107]
- (16) *Bu:dzi-ŋa me-dɯm-nɯ ottha tsiri-ŋa bo:-tsi gana banta*
 shy-INT **NEG-become.3SG-OPT** here tsiri.ritual-INT do-1DU 2SG where
ba-nna taŋma du: ba-nna.
 be-2SG.PST wild.banana grove be-2SG.PST
 ‘May it not be shy, we are doing tsiriŋa here, where did you stay, did you stay in the wild banana grove?’ (ritual chant in which one calls to the wild ginger to reveal itself) [Bungarma, 216]

2.2.2 Stage 2: Subordination of negative optative-marked clause

Stage 1 traced the development of the optative marker. Stage 2 is that in which an optative marked clause, and specifically a negative optative marked clause, comes to be a precautioning clause, with subordinator *rwaksaka*.

In Thulung, the subordination with *rwaksaka* of a clause with an optative marked main verb yields a precautioning clause, which must then be completed by a matrix clause. Without the subordinator *rwaksaka*, we simply have a clause in the optative, which can function independently (as in (13) or (16)); with the subordinator, the interpretation is as a dependent precautioning clause. Thus in (17), which is intentionally incomplete in order to highlight the dependent status of the clause, we have what is interpreted as a precautioning clause; this needs a preemptive clause for resolution, as in (18) below:

- (17) *Dzu-kka me-si:-nɯ rwaksaka ...*
 cold-INST **NEG-die.3SG-OPT** SUB
 ‘So that he not die of cold, ...’ [elicited]

2.2.3 Stage 3: Interpretation of precautioning clause coupled with appropriate main clause as a negative purpose construction.

In the final stage of the proposed pathway, the combination of the precautioning clause with a main clause of appropriate semantics results in a negative purpose construction, with the main clause interpreted as the pre-emptive action which can be (or has been) taken in order to avoid the undesirable outcome expressed by the precautioning clause. As mentioned above, the main clause commonly contains an impersonal deontic necessity construction, but finite verbs are also found. Example (18) takes the precautioning clause from (17) and adds a main clause, while (19) is an example from the New Testament translation.¹⁸

- (18) *Dzu-kka me-si:-nɥ rwaksaka je phɔ-bɛʃ-to.*
 cold-INSTR NEG-die.3SG-OPT SUB clothes wear-CAUS-1SG>3SG
 ‘So that he does not die of cold, I dressed him.’ [elicited]
- (19) *Mer-mim-ka paul mesindɔ me-lɔ-mi-nɥ rwaksaka sela*
 DIST.DEM-PL-ERG Paul there NEG-go-3SG.POL-OPT SUB message
thɯr-so-mɔʃi.
 send-3PL>3SG.POL
 ‘They sent Paul a message so that he would not go there.’ [Acts 19:31]

A few points should be made about the negative purpose construction resulting from the combination of the precautioning and pre-emptive clauses. The order of clauses found in Thulung, with the pre-emptive clause following rather than preceding the precautioning clause, can be seen to come about naturally from the development of the construction: it is unsurprising in an SOV language to find complement clauses occurring before the main verb; clauses, such as precautioning clauses, which are marked with *rwaksaka*, follow this order as well.

Regarding the issue of ‘subject’ identity across clauses, Schmidtke-Bode (2009: 133) has observed in his typology of purpose clauses that negative purpose clauses have a preference for “different, i.e. non-coreferential subjects” (36.9% of his sample, vs. 5.8% for positive purpose clauses); this contrasts with the preference of positive purpose clauses for having the same subject’ (54.2%), while negative purpose clauses only have the same subject in 10.5% of cases. Examples collected through both elicitation and the very limited sample in my narrative corpus all have different subjects across the two clauses of the negative purpose

¹⁸The material in (19) is converted from Devanagari into my transcription system, and I have added glosses and my own translation.

construction. Even if the arguments of the clauses are not always explicitly expressed, as in (18), they are easily recoverable through indexation on the verb.¹⁹ The occurrences of negative purpose constructions in the New Testament corpus generally concur with this same-subject tendency, but exceptions are found, such as (20) where the subject of both clauses is 1SG, as can be seen from the person indexation on the verb:

- (20) *Inima* *nΛ* *me-nə-beŋ-pu-nʌ* *rwaksaka go inima-ɖa*
 2SG.POSS mind NEG-hurt-CAUS-1SG>3SG-OPT SUB 1SG 2SG.POSS-LOC
athawo tsΛkthə me-rok-pa *mulʌ* *be-uto*.
 or nearby NEG-come-NPST.PTCP decision make-1SG>3SG.PST
 ‘In order to not exert pain on your mind, I decided not to come to your place or thereabouts.’ [2 Corinthians 2:1]

To summarize, the negative purposive construction discussed in this section is the main Thulung construction in the apprehensional domain, i.e. used to express potential undesirable events, though it is not particularly frequently found in narratives outside translations. It is formed in an analogous manner to the positive purposive construction in Thulung, and consists of a clause with a (negative) verb form marked with the optative and subordinated by the marker *rwaksaka*. I have presented evidence that the optative mood grammaticalized from a lexical verb ‘be good’ and the subordinator grammaticalized from an anterior converb of a quotative verb.

In the remainder of this paper, I will discuss an alternative strategy to express negative outcomes (§3), and additional functions of the optative (§4).

3 Alternative strategy to express negative outcomes

Thulung can also use an ‘if not’ construction to link a pre-emptive clause to a situation expressing a potential negative outcome, as shown in (21). The linker between the two independent clauses, *me?ema:la*, is a combination of a negative copula and a conditional marker.

¹⁹Thulung argument indexation uses two sets of indexes, one for intransitives (glossed as the index for a single argument, ‘S’), and one for transitives (glossed ‘A>P’). In (17), the precautioning clause has a 3SG S; the pre-emptive clause has a 1SG A (and a 3SG P), as seen from the indexation on the transitive (a causativized intransitive verb) verb *phΛbetto*.

- (21) *Semsan dzəmka tsir-mu ba:si me?ema:la dzhar.*
 firewood carefully stack-INF must otherwise fall.3SG
 ‘Firewood must be stacked carefully; otherwise it will fall.’ [verb dictionary]

Note that undesirability is not expressed through this construction; it must be inferred through an evaluation of the consequence of the realization of the ‘if not’ clause.

The same state of affairs can be expressed, with no discernible semantic differences, as a conditional with a negative protasis, as in (22).

- (22) *Semsan dzəmka me-tsir-ɬ-wa-ma:la dzhar.*
 firewood carefully NEG-stack-3SG>3SG-IRR-COND fall.3SG
 ‘If he doesn’t stack firewood carefully, it will fall.’ [verb dictionary]

In other words, the ‘if not’ construction functions much like a negative conditional, with the difference that it is made up of independent clauses which are linked by *me?ema:la*. The negative consequences are expressed in the second clause of both constructions, and because they are potential (rather than realized), the clause is always non-past. Another example is provided in (23), this time with an imperative verb in the first clause.

- (23) *ʌbʌ mal-ni ma reʔ-ni me?ema:la go gani-lai*
 now search-2PL>3SG.IMP CONJ bring-2PL>3SG.IMP otherwise 1SG 2PL-DAT
pulis-kara ʌ:-nini.
 police-LOC take-1SG>2PL
 ‘Search and bring him, otherwise I will take you to the police.’ (uttered by someone in a story whose child has been kidnapped) [Leledym, 36]

The ‘if not’ construction, seen in (21) and (23), is not considered the primary strategy for a few reasons: the negative purpose construction presented in §2.1 exhibits a stronger causal link between the two clauses, in addition to morphologically encoding undesirability through the negative optative. In the ‘if not’ construction, the second clause factually expresses a likely outcome, should the condition expressed by the first clause not be met, and it is up to the addressee to evaluate the undesirability of the consequence of disregarding expected behavior.

4 The negative impersonal deontic necessity construction

In addition to the pathway described above, whereby *numu* ‘be good’ is the source for the optative mood marker, the same lexical verb has followed a separate grammaticalization pathway, resulting in a negative impersonal deontic necessity construction. The construction is illustrated in examples (24) and (25):

- (24) *Hapa karmar be-si menu.*
 lots hard.work do-IMPER.NMLZ NEG.DEON
 ‘One must not do lots of hard work [while pregnant].’ [Childbirth, 4]
- (25) *Athaldika-wo malo bane-mma nem-gonu tsettse-mim-lai*
 nowadays-even just make-PASS.PTCP house-inside child-PL-DAT
hu:-si menu.
 enter-IMPER.NMLZ NEG.DEON
 ‘Even nowadays, when we make a new house, it is not acceptable for children to enter.’ [Jau Khleu, 232]

The bare verb root takes the impersonal nominalizer *-si*, although occasionally we find an infinitive form of the verb in this construction in the place of the *-si* nominalized form (an infinitive can be considered another type of nominalization). Marker *-si* is assumed to be related to reflexive marker *-si*, which can be used, among other functions, to express an impersonal (see Lahaussais 2016, 2023).

The construction stands in contrast to prohibitives (in other words, negative imperatives, which are inflected for the arguments involved): unlike the latter, it is impersonal, and is used to express recommendations against certain behaviors, generally those going against cultural norms. Thulung prohibitives, on the other hand, refer to specific actions, undertaken by specific agents, rather than to impersonal statements about behavior. See the contrast between (26), the negative deontic necessity construction, and (27),²⁰ the prohibitive:

- (26) *Moṭorsaikal hapa onbe-si menu.*
 motorcycle lots drive-IMPER.NMLZ NEG.DEON
 ‘One shouldn’t drive a motorcycle too fast.’

²⁰Examples (26) and (27) can also be contrasted with the same sentence with a negative optative:

- (i) *Moṭorsaikal hapa me-onbeṭ-nu.*
 motorcycle lots NEG-drive-OPT
 ‘May he not drive the motorcycle too fast.’ / ‘He shouldn’t drive the motorcycle too fast.’ [elicited]

(statement expressing opposition to a certain behavior, not directed at anyone in particular) [fieldnotes]

- (27) *Moʔorsaiƙal hapa me-onbeʔ-ni.*
 motorcycle lots NEG-drive-2PL>3SG.IMP
 ‘Don’t drive the motorcycle too fast!’
 (direct interdiction, aimed at a particular person in a specific instance)
 [fieldnotes]

The development of the negative impersonal deontic necessity construction likely involves a transition from a negated 3SG form of *nɯmu* ‘be good’ following a verb form nominalized with *-si*, with a compositional interpretation of ‘V-ing is not auspicious’, to a construction expressing negative deontic necessity:

- (28) Development of the nominalized verb (INF or *-si*) + NEG-*nɯ* into negative deontic necessity:
 ‘V-ing is not good’ → ‘It is not good to V’ → ‘One shouldn’t V’

This impersonal nature of the construction is reminiscent of the directive infinitive in some SAE languages. According to Van Olmen (2010: 502), “prohibitive speech acts are more face-threatening than their positive imperative counterparts. For that reason, they also have a stronger preference for the more polite directive infinitive” which... “does not require a particular addressee, [and] has a weakly directive illocutionary profile”.

One factor in support of development into a full-fledged construction is that there has been phonological change: the negative marker *me~mi-* is sometimes found in this construction to have assimilated to *mɯ-*, resulting in a marker *mɯnɯ* (and a construction *V-si mɯnɯ*). This change in the negative prefix is only found in this construction.

From the same source verb *nɯmu* ‘be good’, we therefore have two development pathways, resulting in an optative mood marker (which can be negative) on the one hand, and a negative deontic necessity construction on the other, as illustrated in Figure 1. It is interesting that the idea of auspiciousness should feature so prominently in constructions surrounding apprehension and deontic necessity. This ties in nicely with what has been written about Rai religious practice of *mundum*, namely that it “underlies moral values and encourages the behavior that is required to uphold the order defined by the ancestors, which includes self-control, paying attention to one another, and compliance with social order” (Schlemmer 2019).

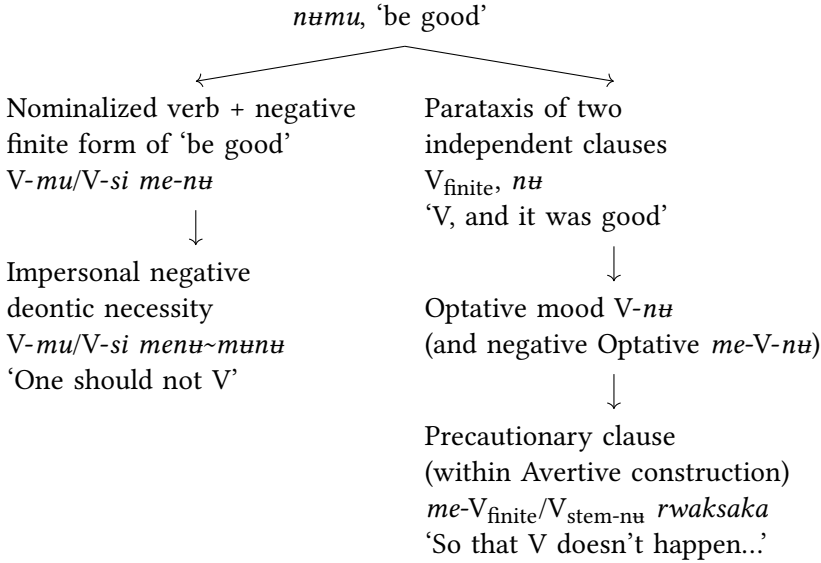


Figure 1: Two development paths from lexical verb *nɯmu*

5 Conclusion

While initial searches of the Thulung corpus revealed no morphology dedicated to expressing apprehension, in concordance with the absence of South Asian languages in descriptions of the apprehensional domain, upon closer inspection it was found that Thulung has nonetheless developed a strategy, in the form of the negative purpose construction. This construction results from the coopting of morphology with other functions, namely a negative optative verb form and a subordinator, in order to yield a precautioning clause which combines with a main clause expressing a pre-emptive action to avert the undesired outcome. This contribution has attempted to provide some empirical data on how the apprehensional domain is expressed in Thulung.

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Abbreviations

1, 2, 3	first, second, third person	NMLZ	nominalizer
ADD	additive ('also')	NPST.PTCP	non-past participle
A	agent argument	OPT	optative
ANT.CVB	anterior converb	PASS	passive
ANTIC	anticipatory Aktionsart (telic)	P	patient argument
APPL	applicative	PI	plural inclusive
CAUS	causative	PL	plural
COND	conditional	POL	polite (for personal pronouns)
CONJ	conjunction	POSS	possessive
DAT	dative	PROX	proximal
DEM	demonstrative	PST	past
DIST	distal	PTCP	participle
DU	dual	PURP	purposive
ERG	ergative	REFL	reflexive
F	feminine	SAE	Standard Average European
GEN	genitive	S	subject of intransitive verb
HS	hearsay	SG	singular
IMP	imperative	SIM.CVB	simultaneous converb
IMPER.NMLZ	impersonal nominalizer	SOC	sociative
INF	infinitive	SUB	subordinator
INSTR	instrumental	TEMP	temporal sequencer
INT	intensifier	TOP	topic
IRR	irrealis	V	verb
LIM	liminal Aktionsart (telic)		
LOC	locative		
NEG	negative		
NEG.DEON	negative deontic		

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